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Demand high for downtown luxury rentals

As the area reinvents itself as a neighborhood, applicants line up for new units; some developments delayed by rising costs

By Brian J. Rogal
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Two years ago, something new began taking shape on the site of the abandoned Chicago Spire project.

Developer Related Midwest launched construction of a 72-story apartment tower, a project it has dubbed 400 Lake Shore Drive,

filling a 76-foot-deep hole left by the failed Spire. Construction is ongoing, but when leasing started in August, renters eagerly began signing leases for units they won't see for months.

"In the first six weeks, we leased more than 100 units in the building," said Curt Bailey, president of Related Midwest. "We're delighted by it, but not really surprised."

As downtown Chicago continues its transformation from a business-focused district into a mixed-use neighborhood with grocery stores, parks and coffee shops, there is huge demand for luxury rentals with amenities and proximity to attractions like the lakefront.

Nearly 50,000 people now live in downtown Chicago, one of the city's fastest-growing neighborhoods, according to the Chicago Loop Alliance.

But high interest rates, rising construction costs and other economic uncertainty have forced downtown developers to delay

breaking ground on many proposed apartment towers. On the rare occasions when new units pop up, applicants flood brokers with requests.

"There is a lot of pent-up demand in our city given the dearth of new deliveries," Bailey said.

Henry Stein said he had to move fast to snag the best unit.

"Our Realtor called at 9 a.m. and said 400 Lake Shore was going to start leasing that

See **RENTALS** on Page A2

BEARS 23, JETS 12



BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

BACKUP POWER

Bears quarterback Tyson Bagent celebrates Sunday's win over the Jets at Soldier Field in Chicago. Backup Bagent served as quarterback for the Bears with Caleb Williams sidelined for the second week with a hamstring injury. **Coverage in Sports**

'Our lofty perch'

Chicago area balloonist shares decades in spellbinding hobby

By Tess Kenny
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

With his hand on the burner, Alan Zielinski looked down at his young passenger and asked for the magic word.

The tight-quartered basket left little room for tricks, but Zielinski, clad in his captain's mitts, continued his urging with a hint of mischief in his voice.

"Come on, Oliver," he beckoned the 5-year-old, who found himself captivated by Zielinski and his hot air balloon at a recent event. "You know bibbidi-bobbidi-boo? How about, 'Alakazam'?"

The boy peered up, his own hands swimming in oversized, navy blue gloves. He paused and then — "Alakazam!" Oliver echoed. Zielinski squeezed the trigger and the fire roared. Above, multicolored nylon billowed, stretching up and up and up toward the sky.

Oliver's hands shot to his ears. The burner thundered again, the blaze hot and bright.



And after one last flash, the display was over as fast as it started. Zielinski asked Oliver if he had his fill of the fanfare. The boy, though his hand muffs stayed firmly in place, shook his head no.

See **BALLOONS** on Page A4

Alan Zielinski's hot air balloon, center, and others light up from their burners firing during the Balloon Glow, part of the Great Forest Park Balloon Race in St. Louis on Sept. 18.

TIM VIZER/FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

ELECTION 2026

Former Illinois House GOP leader Durkin backs Pritzker

Republican politician's support for Democratic governor underscores split in party

By Rick Pearson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Accentuating the schisms that have helped make Republicans the superminority political party in Illinois, former Illinois House GOP leader Jim Durkin said he is endorsing Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker for a third term over Republican nominee Darren Bailey in the Nov. 3 general election.

"His campaign is going nowhere, and he's on a foolish escapade," Durkin said of Bailey, adding that the Republican governor nominee has "a delusional egomaniacal view of the world."

Durkin's refusal to support Bailey's second consecutive bid against Pritzker is not surprising. But his public endorsement of the Democrat, in a video the governor's campaign is scheduled to release Monday, marks a major break for Durkin, who still considers himself a Republican.

"I've worked with Pritzker, and I don't agree with JB on a lot of things. But the fact is, he and I have worked together," Durkin said. He cited Pritzker's investment in infrastructure, the credit upgrades to steady the state's finances and the governor's support for "commonsense gun reforms."

See **GOVERNOR** on Page A3

Presidential vote in Brazil has key link to Trump

Incumbent leader opposes him, other candidate is his ally

By Mauricio Savarese, Eléonore Hughes and Anna-Catherine Brigida
ASSOCIATED PRESS

SAO PAULO — Brazilians began voting Sunday in a high-stakes presidential election pitting incumbent Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva against Sen. Flávio Bolsonaro when the region is shifting to the right in line with the Trump administration.

Bolsonaro, 45, is the son of far-right former President Jair Bolsonaro who is serving a 27-year sentence for a coup attempt and an ally of President Donald Trump.

Lula, who at 80 is one of the world's oldest heads of state, is running in his seventh presidential election and has strengthened Brazil's ties with Beijing.

Trump allies have fared well in recent elections in Latin America, including in Argentina, Colombia, Honduras and Peru.

See **BRAZIL** on Page A8

INSIDE

Germany gives Ukraine \$1.5 billion in aid

German Chancellor Friedrich Merz announced the package of military and energy aid during a visit to Kyiv on Sunday, as Russia escalated its attacks on Ukrainian cities with hard-to-intercept missiles and jet-powered drones. **Nation & World**

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WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 67 L: 49
TUE. H: 70 L: 55
WED. H: 74 L: 52
FULL WEATHER REPORT A10

INDEX

Almanac A8
Arts & Living B5
Comics B8-9
Crossword B9
Editorials A5
Horoscope B8

Nation & World B1
Obituaries A8
Television B7

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